however, would not yet commit to directly opposing Abd un-Nabi, who wanted to execute the Brahmin, and so the Padshah said ‘punishments for offences against the holy law are in the hands of you, the ulema: what do you require of me?’ The sadr then peremptorily ordered the execution of the priest. Thereupon, pandemonium, we are told by Badauni, ensued both inside the harem, because of the ladies, and outside the harem, because of the Hindu courtiers.

So furious and baffled was Akbar by the decision of Abd un-Nabi that he called for a discussion that very night around the Anuptalao water tank at Fatehpur Sikri. All the jurists agreed that the Brahmin’s transgression had not called for such an extreme punishment and that there was an ‘obligation to safeguard infidel subjects’ by Muslim rulers. Badauni, too, agreed that, in case of doubt, clemency was to be preferred but then, inexplicably, began to argue that the sadr, being a very learned man, must have had his reasons to act as he did. He argued so long that ‘the Emperor’s moustache now bristled like the whiskers of a tiger’, and all the courtiers present hissed at him to stop. In the flickering light of the candles, the Padshah’s eyes blazed and he clenched his fists as his increasingly rare temper suddenly erupted. ‘What you say is nonsense,’ thundered Akbar at last and Badauni had no further option but to bow out of the assembly. Badauni, it seems, was hopelessly shackled by his need to display his erudition and contradict the apparently acquiescent jurists. ‘From this time onwards,’ wrote Badauni, ‘the fortunes of Shaikh Abd un-Nabi began to decline’, as, indeed, did those of Badauni himself.

In the year 1578, Akbar continued to tour the empire and to organize hunts wherever he went. These hunts, wrote Qandahari, ‘not only created hysteria in the hearts and minds of his companions, but unleashed a wave of terror among all beasts and birds of that region’. As we have noted, the hunts were a supremely effective display of Akbar’s power and were an opportunity for the Padshah to assess the loyalty of the various chieftains of the empire. In the summer of 1578 Akbar ordered a qumargha to be organized in the vicinity of Bhera, in the Punjab. Over a span of ten days the great nobles of the empire were stationed around the qumargha ring while the beaters drove in animals and birds from miles around. But just as all the arrangements were completed, the birds and animals huddled in the centre, and as Akbar prepared to gallop into the circle of fire, his gleaming sword thirsty for blood, something completely inexplicable happened. ‘A